

HERBAL PREPARATION GUIDE

Personal Reference for the Apothecary Room
47 Atlantic Street, Portland, Maine

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Based on the teachings of Mrs. Virginia Keene, Brunswick, Maine, and Nana Ruth

This guide is for my own reference. These are the preparations I make most often for clients and for the household. They are not prescriptions and they are not instructions I give clients without also reviewing their full health picture first.

PREPARATION 1: STANDARD ALCOHOL TINCTURE (1:5 ratio)

A tincture extracts the medicinal constituents of an herb into alcohol, which acts as a preservative. The finished tincture keeps for several years stored in a dark place.

Materials needed:

- Clean glass jar with tight-fitting lid, quart size
- Amber dropper bottles for finished product
- Cheesecloth or fine mesh strainer
- Small funnel
- Labels
- 60 to 70 percent alcohol (I use 80-proof vodka for most herbs; Virginia Keene used grain alcohol diluted to 60 percent for roots and barks)

Method (fresh herb):

- Fill the jar loosely with fresh, clean herb material. Do not pack tightly.
- Pour alcohol over the herb until fully submerged plus one inch above.
- Seal jar tightly.
- Label with herb name, date, and alcohol used.
- Store in a cool, dark place for four to six weeks.
- Shake gently every two or three days when you remember.
- After six weeks, strain through cheesecloth, pressing the plant material firmly to extract all liquid.
- Pour finished tincture into amber dropper bottles.
- Label with herb name and preparation date.
- Store in the apothecary room, away from direct light.

Method (dried herb):

- Use a 1:5 ratio by weight: 1 part dried herb to 5 parts alcohol.
- For example, 1 ounce of dried herb to 5 ounces (10 tablespoons) of alcohol.
- Otherwise the same process as for fresh herb.

Standard dose for most tinctures: 1 to 2 milliliters (approximately 20 to 40 drops) taken in a small glass of water, two to three times daily. Always adjust for the individual. Always review cautions first.

Current tinctures on the shelf:

- Echinacea aerial parts (made August 2025, 60% ethanol)
 - Valerian root (purchased from Mountain Rose Herbs, not homemade; keep alongside)
 - Lemon balm (made June 2025, 80-proof vodka)
 - Hawthorn berry (purchased)
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PREPARATION 2: CHAMOMILE SLEEP AND CALM TEA BLEND

This is the blend I use most often and the one I keep in tins to give as gifts. I make a large batch in late summer when the chamomile is fully dried.

Ingredients (for a large batch, approximately 60 servings):

- 1 cup dried chamomile flowers
- half cup dried lemon balm leaf
- quarter cup dried lavender flowers (use sparingly; too much is bitter)
- quarter cup dried passionflower leaf (optional; I include it in the blend for clients with more acute anxiety)

Method:

- Combine all dried herbs and mix thoroughly.
- Store in an airtight glass jar away from light and heat.
- Will keep its potency for 12 to 18 months.

To brew: Use 1 heaping teaspoon of blend per cup of water. Steep covered for 10 minutes in water just below boiling. Uncover and drink while warm. Honey may be added but is optional.

Serving suggestion: One cup 30 minutes before bed. Two cups if sleep is difficult. Do not drive after drinking passionflower-containing blends.

PREPARATION 3: COMFREY POULTICE FOR JOINT AND MUSCLE PAIN

This preparation is for external use only. I explain this to every client, without exception. Comfrey contains pyrrolizidine alkaloids that are liver-toxic if ingested.

Materials:

- Fresh comfrey leaves from bed D2 (or dried leaves reconstituted with warm water)
- Clean cloth or gauze strips
- Small bowl and pestle or two stones
- Warm (not hot) water

Method (fresh leaf):

- Pick 4 to 6 large comfrey leaves. Rinse and pat dry.
- Bruise the leaves by pounding gently with a pestle or between two smooth stones until the cell walls break and the leaves release their mucilaginous gel.
- Layer the bruised leaves directly on the affected area (wrist, back, knee, ankle).
- Cover with a clean cloth and hold or wrap loosely to keep in place.
- Leave for 20 to 30 minutes.
- Remove and discard used leaves. Do not reuse.
- Wash hands after handling.

Method (dried leaf):

- Soak 2 tablespoons of dried comfrey leaf in just enough warm water to rehydrate, about 5 minutes.
- Proceed as above once leaves are softened.

Best results: Apply daily for 5 to 7 days for acute joint flares. Always use on unbroken skin only. Do not apply to open wounds or broken skin.

Note: Comfrey contains allantoin, which promotes cell proliferation and reduces inflammation. The traditional use for bruising, sprains, and arthritic joints is well-supported by European herbal research.

PREPARATION 4: LAVENDER INFUSED OIL (COLD METHOD)

This oil is the base for my lavender salve and is also useful on its own for skin and for aromatherapy.

Materials:

- Dried lavender flowers (fresh flowers may introduce moisture and cause spoilage)
- Light carrier oil (I use fractionated coconut oil or almond oil; olive oil is too heavy)
- Clean glass jar with lid
- Cheesecloth and fine strainer
- Amber bottles for finished oil

Method:

- Fill the jar about halfway with dried lavender.
- Pour carrier oil over lavender until all herb is submerged and there are several inches of oil above.
- Seal and label with date and herbs used.
- Place jar in a warm, sunny window for 4 to 6 weeks. A south-facing windowsill works well in summer.
- Shake or stir gently every few days.
- After 6 weeks, strain through cheesecloth, pressing firmly.
- Pour finished oil into amber bottles.
- Label and date. Keeps 12 months.

Use: Applied directly to skin, a few drops massaged into the temples for headache, into the hands before sleep, or onto the chest for a calming effect before bed.

Current batch on shelf: Made June 15, 2025. Good for 12 months; discard if color or scent changes before then.

PREPARATION 5: SAGE THROAT STEAM

This is the simplest preparation I make and one of the most effective for early sore throat and upper respiratory congestion. Nana Ruth used this every winter.

Materials:

- Fresh or dried sage leaves (a small handful)
- Large bowl
- Boiling water (about 4 cups)
- Clean towel

Method:

- Place sage leaves in the bottom of a large heat-safe bowl.
- Pour boiling water over the sage.
- Lean over the bowl, holding your face about 12 inches above the surface.
- Drape the towel over your head and the bowl to trap the steam.
- Breathe slowly and deeply through your nose for 5 to 10 minutes.
- Keep eyes closed.

Repeat once or twice daily at the first sign of a sore throat or nasal congestion.

Note: This is not appropriate for small children or anyone who cannot safely lean over a bowl of hot water. The steam will be hot; always test the temperature before putting your face over the bowl.

I have used this preparation for myself and recommended it to clients for forty years. It is one of the simplest and most reliably comforting things I know how to do.